

Austria Itinerary

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Vienna in 48 Hours: A Capsule Hotel Blunder, Four Bus Lines & a Tower at Midnight

Vienna was our first city of the Europe trip and our first lesson in how a holiday can go sideways in the first hour and still end up beautiful. Two days, all four Hop on Hop off lines, two palaces, one 150-metre tower, an apple strudel, and a hotel room that turned out to be a glorified shelf. This is exactly how it happened.

Day 1

A Train, a Capsule Hotel & the Park Where We Vented

We took one-way tickets to Vienna. After boarding the train and a bit of struggle finding our hotel, we walked into the booking I was most proud of - the one where I'd told Harshit, "Look, the room is so big." It wasn't. During booking, I hadn't realised it was a small **capsule**. Not a room. Other amenities were fine, but I was heartbroken after the blunder. Harshit took it well, the way he always does. He is adjustable in the worst of things. He napped. I couldn't.

Once we'd peeled ourselves out of the capsule, we ate **pasta we'd carried from India** (the start of a long tradition this trip) and headed out for our **Hop on Hop off** pass. Vienna's HoHo runs four routes - **Red, Yellow, Brown and Blue** - and we explored three of them on Day 1, jumping on and off, peering at statues whose names we promptly forgot, and walking the streets.

For dinner we ate **costly and not-so-good burgers**, which I am still slightly bitter about, and were back near the hotel by 5pm. We walked about **3 km** and then collapsed in a park and just talked - about the people, the food, the country in general, and our lives back home in India. The kind of conversation that only happens on Day 1 of a long trip, when you have just enough culture shock to start noticing things.

Day 2

Schonbrunn, Belvedere & 360 Degrees on the Danube Tower

We slept properly and woke up at **7am**. I managed to cook in the room - **rice, poha and dal makhni**. We ate some and packed the rest for later, because if there is one thing an Indian traveller learns fast in Europe, it is that home food is cheaper than a museum sandwich.

Day 2 started with the **Green Line** Hop on Hop off, the line we'd missed yesterday. We bought 24-hour tickets and decided to use our 48-hour Vienna pass to the absolute max. First stop, **Schonbrunn Palace**. The history we picked up on the tour was great in the moment - I will admit honestly that most of it has since slipped out of my head. Then on to **Belvedere Palace**, which is an art museum and therefore - for people like me - boring. But the gardens and the framing of the city through the hedges make it a very good place for pictures, which is what we used it for.

By 5pm we were tired. I told Harshit we should still squeeze in the **Danube Tower**, since it stays open till **11:30 pm**. Best decision of the day. Standing **150 metres above the ground** with a full **360 degree** view of Vienna, in heavy wind, watching the lights of the whole city stretch out - I cannot put it into words and *no picture can do justice* to it. Up there we finally had the city's traditional **apple strudel** and a **Viennese coffee**. The strudel was different and good. The coffee was good and explained, in one sip, why this city has a cafe on every corner.

We came back home around 10pm, packed our bags again, slept around midnight and woke at 4am for the 6:30am train to Prague.

European people know how to celebrate life. They are not earning to enjoy life with family. They are enjoying life and earning to survive.

Vienna Observations (Written on the Train to Prague)

I wrote most of this sitting on the train to Prague while Harshit slept beside me, trying to catch the city before any of it slipped away. After two days, here is what stuck:

- **The architecture is heavy and great.** Apartments, buildings, statues, fountains - the whole skyline carries its weight beautifully.
- **Transportation is hell good.** Bus, tram, cycle, walk - every mode has its own signals and lanes, and it all just works.
- **Drivers stop for pedestrians**, which is highly unlikely in India and took us a full day to trust.
- **Karlplatz and Oper** were our most-used stations. Karlplatz especially is a hub.
- **Language is German**, and we picked up almost none, but people were helpful enough that it never blocked us.
- **Food we didn't explore** - Austria isn't really a vegetarian country, so we mostly cooked.

The line I keep coming back to is the one above the section break. I'd grown up surrounded by the mindset of *earning to enjoy life*. Vienna was the first city that flipped it for me - here it felt like people were *enjoying life and earning to survive*. Completely opposite to what I'd been raised on. I shouldn't complain about my upbringing, but I definitely aspire to adopt a bit of this. Overall it feels like a city to live in. Good work-life balance, I will say.

Vienna Quirks: 3D Chess in the Park & the Ticket Nobody Checked

Two small things I want to record before they fade. First - in the park close to the Danube Tower, there is a **3D chess board** where instead of pieces, real people stand in for the king, queen, bishops and the rest, and a game plays out at human scale. I'd never seen anything like it.

Second - and this is part advice, part confession - **nobody checked our tickets**. Not on a tram, not on a train, not once in two days. By the time we'd figured out how to use the system, it was already time to leave. So when we needed to get to Wien Hbf for the 6:30am train to Prague, we skipped buying the final morning's ticket and walked onto the platform with the calm of seasoned criminals. Did we get away with it? Yes. Do I recommend it? Officially, no.

Must-Visit Places in Vienna

- **Hop on Hop off (all 4 lines)**: Red, Yellow, Brown and Blue cover the city; the Green line tour goes out toward the village edges and was a great experience.
- **Schonbrunn Palace**: The Habsburg summer palace - history-heavy, garden-grand.
- **Belvedere Palace**: Skip it if you hate art museums; do it for the gardens and city-framed photos.
- **Danube Tower**: 150m, 360 degree view, open till 11:30pm. Apple strudel and coffee at the top.
- **3D Chess in the park near Danube Tower**: People stand in as the pieces. Strangely wonderful.
- **Karlplatz station**: Your default Vienna hub.
- **Apple Strudel & Viennese coffee**: The two things you must eat once.
- **48-hour Vienna travel pass**: If you're staying two days, this is the cheapest way to do everything.

Salzburg: A Baroque Stage Set with a Fortress for a Backdrop

A draft from our September notebook — accurate in spirit, still a little raw in the writing.

Salzburg is small enough to walk in a day and dense enough to keep you busy for three. The Old Town sits in a tight bend of the **Salzach river**, hemmed in by two steep wooded hills, with the **Hohensalzburg Fortress** sitting up on one of them like something out of a children's book about kingdoms. From the new town on the opposite bank, the view across the river to the Altstadt is one of those compositions that doesn't really need a photographer to do anything clever. The city has already done the work.

We used Salzburg as a base for five nights — two for the city, one for Werfen, one for Hallstatt, and a buffer day that ended up being the best of the lot. If you're planning the same triangle, this is the place to put your suitcase down.

Day 1

The Altstadt and Getreidegasse

Salzburg's **Altstadt** is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, and you understand why within about ten minutes of arriving. The streets are narrow, the buildings tall and pastel, and almost everything pre-dates the nineteenth century. **Getreidegasse** — the main shopping street — is famous for its wrought-iron guild signs hanging from every shopfront, including, somewhat surreally, over the McDonald's, which is required to comply with the same medieval rules as everyone else.

The Altstadt is also where Mozart was born, in 1756, in a yellow building at **Getreidegasse 9** that's now the **Mozart Geburtshaus** museum. We went; it's small and well-curated and contains his childhood violin, which is the kind of object that does something quiet to you when you stand in front of it. There's a second Mozart house across the river (Mozart-Wohnhaus, where the family lived later) if you want the full set.

Day 2

Hohensalzburg Fortress

The **Hohensalzburg Fortress** has stood on its hill since 1077, has never been successfully taken by siege, and is one of the largest fully-preserved medieval castles in Europe. You can walk up — it's a steady twenty-minute climb on a switchback path — or take the funicular from the Festungsgasse, which is quicker and frankly more fun. We went up on foot and came down on the funicular, which we recommend.

Inside, the highlights are the **Princes' Chambers** (extraordinary late-Gothic woodwork), the marionette museum, and the panoramic terrace, which gives you the postcard view back over the Old Town with the spires of the cathedral and the Franciscan church poking up out of the rooftops, and the Alps standing politely in the background as if waiting for their cue.

From the Hohensalzburg ramparts, Salzburg looks like a model someone built carefully on a table — domes, spires, the river curving past, and the Alps stacked behind it all in soft grey layers.

Day 2

Mirabell Gardens and the Inevitable Sound of Music

Across the river, the **Mirabell Gardens** are a Baroque set piece of clipped hedges, fountains, and a Pegasus statue around which generations of children have been photographed twirling. If you've seen *The Sound of Music*, you'll recognise the steps and the gravel paths immediately — the "Do-Re-Mi" sequence was filmed here, and Salzburg has not stopped trading on this for sixty years.

You can either embrace the Sound of Music tour or studiously avoid it; we did neither and just walked the locations we happened across — Mirabell, the Nonnberg Abbey gate, the lake at Leopoldskron — which felt like the right compromise. The film tour buses are unmistakable. They are also very full, which suggests we may be in the minority.

Day 3

Cathedrals, Squares and Coffee

The **Salzburg Cathedral** (Dom) is enormous, white, and surprisingly austere inside given the Baroque exuberance everywhere else; Mozart was baptised in its font, which is still there. The connected sequence of squares — Domplatz, Residenzplatz, Kapitelplatz with its giant golden orb-and-man sculpture — is the heart of the Old Town and the place where, if you only have an hour, you should spend it.

For coffee, we kept defaulting to **Café Tomaselli**, which has been a coffeehouse since 1700 and feels like it. Newspapers on wooden sticks, waitresses circulating with trays of cakes you point at rather than order, and the slightly imperious atmosphere of a place that doesn't really need your custom. It's wonderful.

A Base for Werfen and Hallstatt

The practical reason to stay in Salzburg rather than somewhere smaller is that it's an excellent launchpad. **Werfen** is forty minutes south on the regional train; **Hallstatt** is two-and-a-bit hours east via Attnang-Puchheim with a single change. Both are doable as day trips, and we did them as such, returning each evening to the same hotel near Mirabellplatz. Storing one suitcase in one place for the whole Austrian leg made everything easier than the alternative — Hallstatt's accommodation is expensive and limited, and we were grateful not to be dragging luggage across a lake ferry.

Must-Visit Places in Salzburg

- **Hohensalzburg Fortress:** Walk up, take the funicular down. Half a day.
- **Getreidegasse & Mozart Geburtshaus:** The yellow house at number 9.
- **Mirabell Gardens:** Free, gorgeous, and yes, the Sound of Music steps.
- **Salzburg Cathedral & Domplatz:** The Baroque heart of the Old Town.
- **Café Tomaselli:** A 1700-era coffeehouse with cake trolleys.
- **Kapuzinerberg viewpoint:** The other hill, far quieter, free, brilliant view.
- **St. Peter's Abbey & cemetery:** Atmospheric, with rock-cut catacombs.
- **An evening Salzach river walk:** Best light on the fortress at golden hour.

Hallstatt: A Lake, a Postcard, a Salt Mine and a Bone House

This is a draft from our field notes — honest about both the magic and the crowds. We'll refine it later.

Hallstatt is the village you've seen even if you don't think you have. It clings to a steep wooded slope above a long alpine lake, the houses stacked tightly between water and cliff, with a slim white church spire rising out of the middle and the Dachstein massif standing behind. The view from the northern end of the village, looking back along the waterfront, is on roughly every "most beautiful villages in Europe" list ever published. It deserves to be. It also pays a price for it.

We came on a day trip from Salzburg, arrived early, and were extremely glad we'd planned it that way. By midday the village had a population spike that exceeded its actual population several times over. The trick to Hallstatt is timing.

Getting There the Long Way Round

From Salzburg, the train takes you to **Hallstatt station**, which is on the wrong side of the lake. You then walk down to a small jetty and board a **boat** that meets each arriving train and ferries you across to the village proper. It's a five-minute crossing, costs a few euros, and is the best possible introduction to the place — the village rises up out of the water in front of you exactly as it does in every photograph, and it's worth the slight rigmarole over driving in.

Driving, incidentally, is discouraged: the village restricts cars, and the parking situation in summer is famously grim. The boat-and-train combination, despite the change, is the right way.

The Skywalk and the World's Oldest Salt Mine

Above the village, accessible by a steep **funicular** from the lakeside, sit the **Hallstatt Salt Mine** and the **Skywalk viewing platform**. The salt mine is the oldest in the world — people have been extracting salt from this mountain for over 7,000 years — and the tour is a proper one: you put on miners' overalls, walk into the mountain, slide down two long wooden miner's slides (genuinely fun), and learn an unexpectedly engrossing amount about the salt economy that made this otherwise tiny village historically important.

The **Skywalk** is a small platform that juts out from the cliff above the village; the view directly down onto the rooftops, the church, the lake bending away into the distance, is the best one in Hallstatt and worth the trip up even if you skip the mine. It's free if you've ridden the funicular up for the mine; you can also walk up, on a steep marked path, in about an hour, which is what we'd do given our time again.

From the Skywalk at 9 a.m., the village looks like a model someone polished overnight: roofs catching the early light, the lake glassy and unbothered, and almost nobody on the streets below. By eleven, that quiet is gone.

The Beinhaus: The Charnel House of St. Michael

Tucked behind the village church is the **Beinhaus** — the bone house — one of the most unexpected and quietly moving things we saw in Austria. The village cemetery is tiny and rocky, and for centuries, when graves were reused, the older skulls were exhumed, cleaned, dried, and painted with the deceased's name, dates, and decorative motifs of flowers, ivy or oak leaves. Around 1,200 of them are still here, arranged on shelves in a small chapel, each one a portrait of a real person.

It is not macabre, exactly. It is patient and intimate and entirely matter-of-fact, the kind of thing that makes you think about the relationship between a community and its dead in a way modern life doesn't usually invite. Entry is a euro or two. It's a quick visit. It will sit with you for a while.

The Crowds (and How to Dodge Them)

Hallstatt has a permanent population of around 750 people and routinely receives 10,000 visitors a day in high season. The arithmetic doesn't work, and the village has been increasingly vocal about it. Tour buses from coach companies arrive in waves through late morning. Cruise-ship day groups appear from nowhere. The famous viewpoint at the north end of the village can have a queue of people waiting to take the photograph.

Two pieces of advice, both well-worn but both true. First: **arrive on the earliest train you can manage**. We were on the 7 a.m. out of Salzburg, on the boat by 9, and had an hour of near-empty village before the wave hit. Second, and better if your budget allows: **stay overnight**. The village empties dramatically by 6 p.m. as the day-trippers leave; an evening walking the lakefront with almost nobody around, and a slow morning before anyone arrives, is by all accounts a completely different Hallstatt. We didn't manage it this trip and we regret it.

What We Skipped (and Would Do Next Time)

We didn't do the **Five Fingers viewing platform** on the Dachstein massif across the lake — a separate cable car up from Obertraun — and from the photographs alone it's clearly worth a day. We also didn't take a **rowing boat out on the lake**, which the village rents from the waterfront and which would have given us the famous view from the water rather than the shore. Both are on the list for next time, and there will be a next time, ideally with one night in the village so we can have it slow.

Must-Visit Places in Hallstatt

- **The Lakeside Viewpoint** (north end): The postcard shot. Early or late.
- **Hallstatt Salt Mine**: World's oldest. Funicular up, miners' slides inside.
- **The Skywalk**: The cliff platform above the village. Unbeatable view.
- **The Beinhaus (Bone House)**: 1,200 painted skulls, behind the church.
- **The Boat Across the Lake**: From Hallstatt station; the right arrival.
- **Marktplatz**: The tiny village square, surprisingly photogenic.
- **Five Fingers Platform** (Obertraun): Separate cable car, worth its own half-day.
- **An Overnight Stay**: The village after the day-trippers leave is the real one.

Werfen: An Ice Cave, an Eagle's Nest Castle, and a Long Way Up

Notes from a long day, written up quickly — a working draft we'll tighten later.

Of the four places we wrote up from this Austrian trip, **Werfen** is the one we knew the least about going in and the one we'll remember the longest. A small town forty minutes south of Salzburg by regional train, it sits in a steep valley between two enormous geographical curiosities: a fairytale castle on a crag on one side, and inside the mountain on the other, the largest ice cave system in the world. You can do both in a single very full day. We did, and we recommend it, with caveats.

The big caveat is the climb. Nobody quite prepares you for how much vertical you do at **Eisriesenwelt**. We did it in early September in walking trainers and were fine; we saw people in flip-flops who were not.

Getting to Eisriesenwelt: The 1,000-Metre Problem

Eisriesenwelt ("World of the Ice Giants") sits at 1,641m up the side of the Hochkogel mountain. Getting from Werfen station to the cave entrance is genuinely a small expedition: a shuttle bus from the village up to the lower car park, a steep fifteen-to-twenty-minute walk to the cable car station, a short and dramatic **cable car ascent** up the cliff, and then another fifteen-minute path along an exposed mountain ledge to the cave mouth. Then, when you get there, the cave tour itself is roughly 600 wooden steps up through the ice.

None of this is technical. All of it is steady, sustained uphill. We watched the cable car queue and made the right decision (queue early). The whole round-trip from leaving the village to getting back to the train station took us about six hours, of which maybe ninety minutes was the actual cave tour.

Inside the Ice: The Tour Itself

The cave system runs for **42 kilometres** underground; tours cover roughly the first kilometre, which is the ice section. The deeper parts are bare limestone and closed to the public. You're handed a carbide lamp at the entrance — there's no electric lighting inside, deliberately, to keep heat out — and you set off in a group with a guide who lights specific formations with magnesium ribbon as you go. The light flares, the ice catches it, and a wall or a column or a fluted curtain of ice appears for a few seconds and then vanishes again. It's theatrical and slightly surreal and you very quickly stop caring about your camera, which doesn't work in there anyway.

It is also extremely cold. The cave hovers around 0°C year-round, and a steady draft funnels through it. We had fleeces and light puffer jackets and that was the minimum; people who'd come up in shorts and t-shirts (you'd be surprised how many) suffered visibly. **If we'd written this guide in advance for ourselves, the headline would have been: bring proper layers even in July.**

A magnesium flare in the dark, and suddenly a 20-metre wall of clear blue ice catches the light for three seconds before the cave swallows it again. We are very deliberately not allowed to photograph this. It's better that way.

Hohenwerfen Castle: The "Where Eagles Dare" Fortress

Back down in the valley, on the opposite side, **Hohenwerfen Fortress** sits on a 155m rocky bluff above the river. It's the castle from *Where Eagles Dare* (1968) — the film with Richard Burton and Clint Eastwood — which is why a certain generation of British visitor in particular makes a pilgrimage here.

We're in that generation. We made the pilgrimage.

The castle dates from 1077, has the usual blend of defensive towers, dungeon, weapons collection, and well-preserved Gothic chambers, but the real draw — apart from the cinematic association — is the **falconry demonstration** held in the inner courtyard twice a day. We caught the afternoon one. Vultures, eagles, falcons flying low over the heads of the crowd against the backdrop of the Alps; you don't have to be an especially enthusiastic birder for it to land. We were not, and it did.

Logistics: Can You Do Both in a Day?

Yes, but only just. The combined ticket from Werfen tourist office covers both attractions and is cheaper than two separate ones. Our running order: early train from Salzburg, shuttle bus straight up to Eisriesenwelt to beat the queue, cave tour in the late morning, lunch back in the village, then up to Hohenwerfen for the 3:15 falconry display, then the late afternoon train back to Salzburg. It worked. It was tight. We slept on the train.

If you have the time and like castles more than caves, you could split it across two days; if it's the other way round, Eisriesenwelt absolutely deserves its own unhurried day.

What to Bring (Honestly)

This is the practical bit we wished someone had told us. For Eisriesenwelt: **warm layers** (fleece minimum, jacket better), **proper closed shoes** with grip, **gloves** if you're prone to cold hands, a small backpack you can climb stairs with, and water. For the castle: nothing special, but the falconry is outside so a hat or rain layer depending on the day. For both: cash, in case card readers are slow; the queues here can be long enough that you don't want to be the cause of further delay.

Must-Visit Places in Werfen

- **Eisriesenwelt Ice Cave:** 42km cave system, world's largest. Half a day minimum.
- **The Cable Car Ascent:** Short, dramatic, far easier than the alternative footpath.
- **The 600-Step Cave Tour:** Carbide lamps, magnesium flares, year-round 0°C.
- **Hohenwerfen Fortress:** 1077 castle, the "Where Eagles Dare" location.
- **Falconry Display:** Twice daily in the fortress courtyard; do not miss.
- **Werfen Village:** Tiny, sweet, useful lunch stop between the two sites.
- **Combined Eisriesenwelt + Castle Ticket:** Buy at the tourist office.

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